

# Satti of Dongola

Where the name comes from, the best-documented family line that carries it, and how to connect your own branch when written records are thin.

**Short answer.** “Satti” (ساتي) is a Nubian word from the Dongolawi (Andaandi) language. It means “the poor one,” in the Sufi sense of a *faqīr*: a Qur’an reciter dedicated to God. It started as a title for holy men around Old Dongola and became a common given name there. In Sudan, an ancestor’s given name often turns into a family surname, so a Satti family is almost certainly descended from a Dongolawi man called Satti.

The earliest and best-recorded bearer is the 16th-century saint **Muhammad “Satti” Suwar al-Dhahab** of Old Dongola. His descendants are still known in al-Ghaddar, Omdurman and El Obeid. Your family’s oral pedigree places you in his family on both sides: **Sawarab** through your father’s line and **Ziyadab** through a maternal line, with home villages at Old Dongola and Bina. Both clans trace back to him, so your line most likely meets his twice.

**Your two trees:** Father’s side · Satti (Ziyadab × Sawarab) ·

Mother’s side · Ja’aliyin (‘Abbas)

● **DOCUMENTED** printed or archaeological source

● **TRADITION** family or tribal genealogy

● **INFERENCE** my reasoning

● **UNKNOWN** needs your family

## What “Satti” means

# Satti

ساتي

|             |                                                                             |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LANGUAGE    | Dongolawi Nubian (Andaandi)                                                 |
| LITERAL     | “the poor one” (a <i>faqīr</i> )                                            |
| SENSE       | a Qur’an reciter devoted to God                                             |
| LATER USE   | an honorific like <i>Sayyid</i> or <i>Shaykh</i> , then a common given name |
| NOT RELATED | the Satti tribe of Pakistani Punjab and Kashmir                             |

The historian Ahmad Ibrahim Abu Shouk writes that “Satti,” added to the name of Shaykh Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab, is لقب منحوت من اللغة النوبية (الدقلاوية), a title taken from Dongolawi Nubian. It means the poor one, or a Qur’an reciter given to God. He says it then became *a common name in the Dongola region and an honorific equal to Sayyid or Shaykh*. ● DOCUMENTED

The word is regional, which helps your search. Satti is rare outside the Dongola reach of the Nile, roughly from Kerma to al-Dabbah. A Sudanese family called Satti is very likely Danagla, the people of Dongola.

● INFERENCE

Ancestry.com and Geneanet trace “Satti” to a Rajput clan in Pakistan. That is a different word with a different history. Expect false matches from those sites and ignore them for a Sudanese line. ● DOCUMENTED

**How it became a surname.** Sudanese names are a chain: your own name, then your father’s, then your grandfather’s, and so on. Families abroad and in official papers often freeze one link of that chain as a surname. If Satti is your surname, a man named Satti is usually one to four generations above you. He was probably named in honour of a holy ancestor or a local saint.

● INFERENCE

02 • DEEP ANCESTRY

## The layers beneath a Dongolawi family

Any Satti line from Dongola sits on the same stack of history. You can’t name individuals before about 1500, but you can say whose land it was.

c . 2500–1500 BCE

## Kerma

The first great Nubian kingdom, centred just north of Dongola. Its people are the deep ancestors of the Nile Nubians.

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c . 800 BCE–350 CE

## Kush: Napata and Meroë

The Kushite kingdom ruled from upriver at Napata and Meroë. Dongola lay at its heart.

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c . 550–1300s

## Makuria, a Christian kingdom with Old Dongola as its capital

Old Dongola (Tungul) was the royal seat. The 652 *Baqt* treaty with Egypt kept it independent for six centuries. Dongolawi, the language that gave us “Satti,” descends from the speech of this kingdom.

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1317–1500s

## Islamisation and Arab marriage ties

Makuria’s throne hall became a mosque in 1317. Arab groups, including those later called Ja’aliyin, married into Nubian families. Genetic studies date the main Arab–Nubian admixture in the Danagla to about 855–1095 CE. That suggests the mixing began long before the kingdom fell.

● DOCUMENTED

1504–1821

## Funj era: the holy families

Sufi scholars founded Qur’an schools (*khalwas*) around Old Dongola. The Suwar al-Dhahab family was among the most revered, and the title “Satti” comes from this world.

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1821–present

## Turkiyya, Mahdiyya and dispersal

Danagla merchants and soldiers spread to Kordofan, Omdurman and Khartoum, then abroad. Many Satti families today live far from Dongola but still trace back to a home village there.

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03 • FAMILY TREE • YOUR FATHER’S SIDE

## The Suwar al-Dhahab line, where “Satti” is first recorded

This is the oldest documented family where “Satti” appears as a name. The dashed gaps are generations that no published source names. The bottom row shows the three known branches and where your own line would attach.

al-‘Abbas ibn ‘Abd al-Muttalib العباس

● TRADITION

Uncle of the Prophet, died about 653. The Ja‘aliyin, and the Bedairiya within them, trace their descent to him. Historians treat this as a claimed pedigree, not a biological record.

‘Abdallah ibn al-‘Abbas عبد الله

● DOCUMENTED

A real historical figure: the Companion and Qur’an scholar, died about 687. His being in the Ja‘ali chain is the tradition; the man himself is documented.

‘Ali · Muhammad · al-Fadl · Sa’d · Muhammad Dhu al-Kala’ · Ahmad · Muhammad Hatil · Kurb · Qasas · ‘Adi · Yaman · Qays

Idris → Ibrahim Ja‘al إبراهيم جعل

● TRADITION

Idris is said to be the ‘Abbasid who came to Nubia. His son Ibrahim Ja‘al gives the Ja‘aliyin their name. A second version of the chain reaches Ibrahim through Ahmad al-Yamani instead.

Ahmad · Masruq · ‘Abdallah Harqan · Qada’a · Abu al-Dis · Kardam · Sarar · Samra

Badir بدير

● TRADITION

Namesake ancestor of the Bedairiya, who are counted as part of the Ja‘ali group. His sons include Dahmash (the Dahmashiya), Hilal and Aghbash. Bedairiya genealogies list Shaykh ‘Isa and Shaykh Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab among the Bedairiya. Wikipedia’s note on Satti Majid puts the family in the “Zubaid section” of the tribe.

generations unrecorded

Salih al-Badiri صالح البديري

● TRADITION

## Shaykh ‘Isa ibn Salih al-Badiri عيسى

● DOCUMENTED

Known as *jadd al-mayya*, “ancestor of the hundred.” He had ten sons who each had about ten scholar sons. He studied under ‘Abd al-Rahman ibn Jabir, according to the *Kitab al-Tabaqat*. Some sources call him ‘Isa Suwar al-Dhahab and give his death as 1070 AH (about 1660). He is said to be a maternal cousin of Shaykh ‘Abdallah al-Aghbash, under whom he studied Qur’an recitation.

## Shaykh Muhammad “Satti” Suwar al-Dhahab ساتي

محمد سوار الذهب

● DOCUMENTED

Founder of the family Qur’an school at Old Dongola. He is the first man recorded with the title “Satti.” Tradition says he brought the al-Duri reading of the Qur’an to Sudan around 1504. Evliya Çelebi saw a Suwar al-Dhahab tomb at Old Dongola in the early 1670s. The *Tabaqat* links him to King Qashqash of Dongola, whose existence a 2026 excavation confirmed.

BRANCH A • STAYED IN  
DONGOLA

## Ziyadab family

الزياداب

● DOCUMENTED

They trace their descent to “Satti Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab.” Home village: al-Ghaddar, a few miles from Old Dongola.

≈ 8–10 generations

## Majid Muhammad al-Qadi

● TRADITION

Father, from his full name. The family were religious judges, hence “al-Qadi.”

## Shaykh Satti Majid (1883–1963)

● DOCUMENTED

Born and buried at al-Ghaddar. Known as “Shaykh al-Islam in North America,” he lived in the US from 1904 to 1929. In 1941 the villagers made him head of the family’s religious seat (the *sajjada*).

BRANCH B • MOVED SOUTH  
(SAWARAB)

## al-Nur Suwar al-Dhahab

● TRADITION

Sent by the Funj sultan of Sennar to teach in Kordofan. Settled in El Obeid.

## Salih al-Nur

● TRADITION

Received the Khatmiyya Sufi order from Muhammad ‘Uthman al-Mirghani.

## Mirghani & Hassan

● TRADITION

Mirghani led Danagla fighters in the Mahdist war. Hassan built the Sawarab mosque in Omdurman.

## Field Marshal ‘Abd al-Rahman Swar al-Dahab

● DOCUMENTED

Led Sudan’s 1985–86 transitional government, then stepped down voluntarily. Died in 2018.

BRANCH C • YOUR LINE  
(ZIYADAB × SAWARAB)

## Ziyadab and Sawarab, from the saint

● GAP

About 6–8 unnamed generations back to Muhammad “Satti” Suwar al-Dhahab. Your recited chain ends in “Zeyadab”. Your family also counts the Sawarab on the father’s side. Published sources trace both clans to the saint.

## Hassan حسن

● FROM YOU

The oldest name in your recited chain. Roughly born 1760–1810. Home villages: Old Dongola and Bina.

## Khabir (Haber) خبير

● FROM YOU

Remembered as the Suwar al-Dhahab man who divorced and remarried several times; his children took their mother’s clan name, Ziyadab. Where Salih fits in the chain is still open.

## Hassan حسن

● FROM YOU

Roughly born 1820–1860, in the Turkiyya era.

## Satti Mohamed

ساتي محمد

● FROM YOU

The ancestor your surname comes from. “Satti Mohamed” is the same form as the saint’s own name, “Satti Muhammad” Suwar al-Dhahab, so he was likely named in the saint’s honour. ● INFERENCE

## Mohamed Osman

محمد عثمان

● FROM YOU

Your grandfather. As a single name, “Mohamed Osman” usually honours Sayyid Muhammad ‘Uthman al-Mirghani, founder of the Khatmiyya Sufi order. ● INFERENCE

## Kamal کمال

● FROM YOU

Your father.

## Mohamed Kamal

محمد کمال ساتي

● FROM YOU

You. Seven generations named, back to the first Hassan.

# The Ja'aliyin line: Hamed to Abbas

This is a separate family from the Satti line above. It belongs to your mother. They are Ja'aliyin from Metemma, and the family later lived in Omdurman.

Ja'aliyin الجعليين

● TRADITION

From **Metemma**, the old seat of the Nafi'ab meks on the west bank of the Nile opposite Shendi; later in Omdurman. The section (*khashm al-bait*) is still to be confirmed: Nafi'ab, Sa'dab or 'Awadiya are the likeliest.

Hamed حامد (or Ahmed)

● FROM YOU

The oldest name remembered. Roughly born 1770–1800, in the late Funj period. “Hamed” is the more likely form.

Mohamed محمد

● FROM YOU

Roughly born 1800–1830.

Isa عيسى

● FROM YOU

The Isa ancestor, confirmed by the family as Isa (not 'Isawi). Roughly born 1830–1860, during the Turkiyya.

Osman عثمان

● FROM YOU

Roughly born 1860–1890. He would have lived through the Mahdiyya, when Omdurman became the capital (1885–98).

Abdalla عبد الله

● FROM YOU

Abbas عباس

● FROM YOU

Your mother's father. The family calls his line **Hadarbi** (Hedeerbi). He married a woman of the **Baqlab**, your mother's mother's people.

Your mother, then you

● FROM YOU

Full name chain: **عبد الله عثمان عيسى محمد حامد**, read as Abbas son of Abdalla son of Osman son of Isa son of Mohamed son of Hamed. That is six generations, back to about 1780.

What the research has ruled in and out

| LEAD                                                                      | FINDING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | STATUS                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Metemma origin (confirmed by the family)                                  | Metemma was the seat of the Nafi‘ab meks from 1558 to 1821, rivals of their Sa‘dab cousins at Shendi. The ‘Awadiya, the most numerous Ja’aliyin section, also live in the villages of Shendi and Metemma.                                                                        | ● FROM YOU                                |
| How the family likely reached Omdurman: the Metemma massacre, 1 July 1897 | The Mahdist commander Mahmud wad Ahmad sacked Metemma and killed the Ja’aliyin leader ‘Abdallah wad Sa’d. MacMichael says over 2,000 died. The women and children were taken to the Mahdist treasury in Omdurman. Osman, born about 1860–90, belongs to exactly that generation. | ● EVENT DOCUMENTED<br>● LINK TO YOU: LEAD |
|                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                           |

| LEAD                                                                                                | FINDING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | STATUS                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>“Hadarbi”:</b><br/> <b>your mother’s father’s line</b><br/> (حضري، from الحضارية Hadarba)</p> | <p>Sudanese genealogies list the Hadarba (also Hadarma or Hadareb) as people from <i>Hadramawt</i> in Yemen. They are said to have crossed the Red Sea, settled at Suakin among the Beja and ruled there. The traveller Mansfield Parkyns (1853) called the people of Suakin “Hadarba” and noted that they were enterprising traders. A Hadarbi family living among the Ja’aliyin of Metemma would most likely descend from such traders and have joined the Ja’aliyin by marriage.</p> | <div>● GROUP DOCUMENTED</div> <div>● LINK: LIKELY, NEEDS THE ARABIC SPELLING</div> |
| <p><b>Baqlab</b><br/> (بقلاب): your mother’s mother’s clan</p>                                      | <p>Not found in MacMichael or online under this spelling. The “-ab” ending marks a family clan named after an ancestor, probably one of the small houses of the Metemma area.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <div>● NEEDS ARABIC SPELLING</div>                                                 |
|                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                    |

| LEAD                                                                                                                                  | FINDING                                                                                                                                                                                                   | STATUS                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <p><b>Wad Hamid</b><br/>(ود حامد), a town in Metemma locality</p>                                                                     | <p>The name means “son of Hamid”, and most of its people are said to descend from one family. Your oldest remembered ancestor is Hamed. This may only be a shared name, but it is worth asking about.</p> | <div>● WEAK LEAD</div> |
| <p>‘Isawiya section of the Jamu‘iya, south Omdurman (Mek ‘Isawi, d. about 1801)</p>                                                   | <p>The family confirms the ancestor was Isa, not ‘Isawi. Isa was also born about two generations too late to be Mek ‘Isawi.</p>                                                                           | <div>● RULED OUT</div> |
| <p>Jamu‘iya and Ja’aliyin houses of Omdurman: Fatihab (Abu Si‘id), Nailab, Kitayab (al-Masalma), and the Jamu‘iya of al-‘Abbasiya</p> | <p>These are the main Ja’aliyin-group families with old roots in Omdurman. None is yet tied to this chain.</p>                                                                                            | <div>● OPEN</div>      |
| <p>Families that moved to Omdurman from Shendi, Metemma or al-Damer during or after the Mahdiyya</p>                                  | <p>Many Ja’aliyin families arrived in Omdurman from the 1880s. Osman’s generation fits that timing.</p>                                                                                                   | <div>● OPEN</div>      |
|                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                        |

| LEAD                                                                                | FINDING                                                                                  | STATUS     |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| A web search for this exact chain (عيسى, محمد حامد, عثمان عيسى, عبدالله عثمان عيسى) | No published family tree or notable person matches. That is normal for a private family. | ● NO MATCH |

#### 04 • HOW SURE IS EACH CLAIM

## What is solid and what is not

| CLAIM                                                                                              | STATUS       | BASIS                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Satti” is a Dongolawi Nubian title meaning a <i>faqir</i> or Qur’an reciter                       | ● DOCUMENTED | Abu Shouk (historian), cited in Wikipedia. One scholarly voice; no Nubian dictionary entry found yet.                          |
| The Suwar al-Dhahab holy family were established at Old Dongola by the 1600s                       | ● DOCUMENTED | <i>Kitab al-Tabaqat</i> , Evliya Çelebi’s 1670s travels, and the 2026 <i>Azania</i> study.                                     |
| Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab was the son of ‘Isa ibn Salih al-Badiri                                   | ● TRADITION  | Abu Shouk. <i>Al-Sharq al-Awsat</i> instead calls him an immigrant from Arabia who arrived in 1504. The two accounts conflict. |
| The family are Bedairiya, of Ja’ali and ‘Abbasid descent                                           | ● TRADITION  | Tribal genealogies. Scholars note that many Danagla are Arabised Nubians and may not be Ja’aliyin at all.                      |
| Every Sudanese Satti descends from the saint                                                       | ● UNLIKELY   | The name spread as an honorific, so many unrelated men were given it.                                                          |
| Your family is Sawarab on the father’s side and Ziyadab on the mother’s, from Old Dongola and Bina | ● TRADITION  | Your family’s oral pedigree. It fits the published sources: both clans are Suwar al-Dhahab descendants at Old Dongola.         |

| CLAIM                                                    | STATUS    | BASIS                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The exact generations between Salih/Khabir and the saint | ● UNKNOWN | About 7–9 names. Kept by the Suwar al-Dhahab <i>sajjada</i> at Old Dongola and by the oldest Sawarab and Ziyadab elders. |

05 · CLOSING THE GAP

## Researching without written records

In northern Sudan, the record is mostly oral, and it's often good for 8 to 12 generations. Here is the order that works best.

### 1. Record the name chain

Ask the oldest relatives to recite the full chain: “X son of Y son of Satti son of ...”. Ask for each link in Arabic, because spellings drift in English.

### 2. Get the village and the khalwa

Ask which village the family “belongs to” (بلدنا). Is it al-Ghaddar, Old Dongola, al-Khandaq, Argo or Kerma? Ask which saint's tomb the family visits, and which Qur'an school the grandfathers attended.

### 3. Ask the tribe and section

Ask whether the family say they are Danagla, Bedairiya, Ja'aliyin or Shaiqiya, and which section (*khashm al-bait*), for example Ziyadab or Sawarab. Section names tie you to published tribal trees.

### 4. Contact the sajjada

The Suwar al-Dhahab religious seat at Old Dongola and the Sawarab mosque in Omdurman keep genealogies. Elders there can say whether your chain joins theirs.

### 5. Search the printed sources

Look at the *Kitab al-Tabaqat* (Yusuf Fadl Hasan's edition), MacMichael's *A History of the Arabs in the Sudan* (1922), which reprints tribal *nisba* trees, and the Sudan Archive at Durham University, which holds colonial-era Dongola Province files.

## 6. Test male-line DNA

A Y-DNA test of a male Satti, alongside a male from a known Suwar al-Dhahab or Ziyadab line, can confirm or rule out a shared father line. Danagla men mostly carry haplogroups J and E1b1b, so you need fine-grained testing such as Big Y, not just the haplogroup.

To build the next version of this tree, send me:

1. Your name chain as far back as anyone can recite it, in Arabic if possible.
2. The home village in the Dongola area.
3. Any tribe or section name your elders use.
4. Any family saint, mosque or khalwa they mention.

The National Records Office in Khartoum holds Turkiyya and Condominium records. Access has been badly disrupted since the war began in April 2023, so check before relying on it.

### SOURCES

## Where this comes from

1. Abu Shouk, A. I., “Satti Majid Muhammad Suwar al-Dahab: Shaykh al-Islam in North America,” [Sudanile](#) (Arabic). Source for the meaning of “Satti” and the ‘Isa, Muhammad and Ziyadab chain.
2. [Satti Majid](#), Wikipedia, and [ساتي ماجد](#), Arabic Wikipedia.
3. “Sawar,” *Al-Sharq al-Awsat* (Arabic). Source for the Sawarab branch from Old Dongola to El Obeid and Omdurman.
4. Barański, Obłuski & Wyżgoł (2026), “The King of Nubia at work,” *Azania*; summary at [SciTechDaily](#).
5. [Danagla](#), [Dongolawi language](#) and [Bedaria tribe](#), Wikipedia.
6. Sirak et al. (2021), “[Social stratification without genetic differentiation at Kulubnarti](#)”, *Nature Communications*. Source for the Danagla admixture dates.
7. “[al-Bedairiya al-Dahmashiya](#),” Sudanese Online forum (Arabic). A tribal genealogy, used for the upper tree only.
8. *Kitab al-Tabaqat* by Wad Dayf Allah, [electronic text](#) (Arabic).
9. [Ancestry](#) and [Geneanet](#). These describe the unrelated Pakistani Satti surname.